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Source: *Acta Classica*, 2014, Vol. 57 (2014), pp. 127-154

Published by: Classical Association of South Africa

Stable URL: https://www.jstor.org/stable/24593589

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ACTA CLASSICA LVII (2014) 127-154 *ISSN* 0065-1141

CONSTANTIUS AND THE SIEGES OF AMIDA AND NISIBIS: AMMIANUS' RELATIONSHIP WITH JULIAN'S *PANEGYRICS*[*]

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ABSTRACT

Although the emperor Julian appears as the dominant character within the extant portion of Ammianus Marcellinus' *Res Gestae*, Ammianus' relationship with Julian's writings has rarely been investigated. This article argues that Ammianus models aspects of his description of the siege of Amida in 359 upon the narrative of the siege of Nisibis in 350 in Julian's two panegyrics to Constantius. Ammianus' intertextuality with Julian is designed to provide a subtle denigration of Constantius by offering a corrective reading of Constantius' most notable military triumph against the Persian king Sapor.

Introduction

Ammianus and Julian are inextricably linked in modern scholarship. Julian has left us a richer selection of his own writings than any other emperor, but their largely philosophical and rhetorical nature has allowed Ammianus' expansive, classicising history to assume a central position as *the* narrative of Julian's political and military career. Ammianus' narrative frequently serves as a chronological framework against which to plot Julian's literary productions.[1]

Rarely, however, have Julian's works been read as intertextual sources for Ammianus' *Res Gestae*.[2] Despite the centrality of Julian to Books 15-25 of Ammianus, Julian the historical protagonist rather than Julian the author has dominated studies of the *Res Gestae*. In addition to the

[*] Earlier versions of this paper were presented at the 10th Shifting Frontiers in Late Antiquity conference in Ottawa, and at the Classics Colloquium at the University of KwaZulu-Natal, Durban. I thank both audiences and the journal's anonymous readers for their helpful comments and suggestions. Any errors remain my own.

[1] Cf. Bowersock 1978:6.

[2] Chapter 9, pp. 293-320, of Sabbah 1978 provides an exception. He does not deal with the *Panegyrics*, however.

DOI 10.15731/AClass.057.07

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difference in subject matter between the works of Julian and Ammianus,[3] there have been inherent difficulties in identifying allusions between Ammianus' Latin and Julian's Greek.[4] Ammianus published his *Res Gestae* almost twenty-five years after Julian's death,[5] toward the end of a period of intense contemporary debate over the legacy of Julian's career for the religion, culture and security of the Empire.[6]

This article sets out to do two things. Ultimately, it provides a case for reading one of the most famous episodes of Ammianus' *Res Gestae* – the siege of Amida by the Persians in 359 during which the historian was among the defenders – in the light of Julian's narrative of a similar scene-type in his panegyrics to Constantius. It reveals Ammianus' methods of composition and the nature of his engagement with contemporary literature. In so doing, I also make some observations on the types of intertextuality which appear to be at play in Ammianus' work. The role of intertextuality in historiography is a topic of current debate, particularly relating to Classical Latin historians. What follows at the end of the paper is designed to provide a Late Antique perspective to recent discussions.[7]

I begin, however, with an analysis of Julian's text itself, and the use to which Julian puts narrative within his encomia.

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[3] The survival of Julian's *biblidion*, a pamphlet which narrated his victory at the battle of Strasbourg in 357, would have provided an interesting *comparandum* for Ammianus' historiographical narrative. For the nature of the *biblidion* see Janiszewski 2006:113-16.

[4] Ammianus was a native Greek speaker, a fact which increases the likelihood that he was sufficiently well-read in Greek literature to deploy allusions to Greek authors, but his chosen medium of Latin provides a methodological challenge to this process especially on the lexical level.

[5] The *Res Gestae* was published in the form we have it around AD 390. For a recent survey of the arguments in favour of this date, see Kulikowski 2012:81-82.

[6] For Gregory Nazianzen's *Oration* 5 against Julian and Libanius' *Epitaphios* (both composed in 365) as important attempts to shape Julian's legacy in light of the death of Jovian, Procopius' rebellion and the continued threat from Persia, see Elm 2012:433-45. There was a series of (lost) works published on Julian's Persian campaign between Julian's death in 363 and the 390s: Philagrius, Magnus of Carrhae, Eutychianus of Cappadocia and possibly Seleucus of Emesa, for whom see Janiszewski 2006:121-44. They also act as testament to the enduring interest in Julian's career during the latter half of the 4th century. In a letter of 358 (Libanius *Ep.* 30, Norman), Libanius congratulates Julian on his panegyric to Constantius, thus suggesting that these speeches were in circulation soon after their composition.

[7] A survey of intertextual theory, terminology and current practice follows in 'Ammianus, Sieges and intertextuality' below.

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Narrative and panegyric

Of all Julian's extant works, his panegyrics are, in terms of genre, the most proximate to Ammianus' history. Although there were anxieties in the imperial period about the opposing nature of panegyric and historiography,[8] these were as much a result of the similarities between the two genres as their differences. Roger Rees neatly sums up the relationship between the genres in a recent article:

> Both were essentially ethical; both dedicated much time to political leaders, their qualities, habits and achievements in theatres such as war, domestic politics and their own homes. Cicero even yoked panegyric and historiography together as epideictic genres, each with a particular interest in narrative.[9]

Panegyric thus contained portions of narrative which were distinctly historical in terms of content. Recent narrative theorists such as White have argued that historical narrative, although being the dominant vehicle for representing past events, inherently shapes the interpretation of the events it narrates and can be neither neutral nor objective.[10] White's observations are confirmed by the example of narrative embedded within panegyric: historical narrative in panegyric must necessarily support the rhetorical objective of the speech as a whole, to praise its subject.[11] Rees goes on to demonstrate how narrative played a central function in panegyric, namely by providing a *cognitio gestorum* relating to the honorand's career, supporting evidence for his ethical qualities, and even an emotive

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[8] Lucian in the 2nd century (*Hist. Conscrib.* 7) stated: οὐ στενῷ τῷ ἰσθμῷ διώρισται καὶ διατετείχισται ἡ ἱστορία πρὸς τὸ ἐγκώμιον, ἀλλά τι μέγα τεῖχος ἐν μέσῳ ἐστὶν αὐτῶν ('The dividing line and frontier between history and panegyric is not a narrow isthmus but rather a mighty wall').

[9] Rees 2010:107. The references to Cicero are to *Orat.* 37.66 and *De Orat.* 2.35-36.

[10] A central point of White 1987. Cf. a later formulation in White 2010:274: 'far from being a neutral medium in which events, whether imaginary or real, can be represented with perfect transparency, narrative is an expression in discourse of a distinct mode of experiencing and thinking about the world, its structures, and its processes.'

[11] Gibson 2004 has demonstrated that knowledge of historical events and their representation by ancient historians played a key part in the rhetorical training provided by *progymnasmata* throughout the imperial period, including the 4th century. Historical narrative was closely bound up with rhetoric training.

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function through entertainment and pleasure for the audience, what Rees calls the 'cognitive', 'evidentiary' and 'celebratory' functions respectively.[12]

Rees compiles his taxonomy from the Latin tradition of the *Panegyrici Latini*. However, as examples written by one member of the imperial family to another, Julian's Greek speeches are unique examples of their genre.[13] Composed in the mid- to late-350s, both are addressed to Julian's senior emperor, Constantius II. During this period Julian was consolidating his position as Caesar, to which he had been elevated by Constantius in 355, before he rebelled against Constantius in 360.[14] The tensions between the Augustus and his Caesar are particularly apparent in the second speech. In both, however, Julian has often been accused of slavish imitation of the precepts of the *basilikos logos* set out by Menander Rhetor.[15] However, Tougher and Drake have recently sketched a picture of Julian as an innovative and subversive panegyricist, who manipulates generic conventions to condemn Constantius under a veneer of praise.[16]

Even if Julian subtly attacks Constantius in both speeches, the superstructure remains that of panegyric which has the outward aim of praising him. Narration of one event in particular appears in both speeches: the successful defence of the Mesopotamian stronghold of Nisibis against a Persian siege led by King Sapor II in 350.[17] Sieges were standard fare for historiography, and so a survey of Julian's narrative strategy of this scene-type within his panegyrics may provide a *comparandum* for Ammianus' own siege descriptions within historiography.[18]

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[12] Rees 2010:108-18. White would object that, there being no such thing as objective narration of events, *cognitio gestorum* cannot be disconnected from other narrative aims. In any case, Rees (2010:110) downplays the role of the cognitive function by suggesting that in a performance context, the audience already knew the majority of details of the honorand's career: 'there can be no cognitive function when the orator's challenge is to say what is already known.' For the relevance of this for Julian's speeches, see below.

[13] Julian also composed a third panegyric, to Constantius' wife Eusebia (*Or.* 2).

[14] The dates of composition are still debated, but it seems likely that the first panegyric (*Or.* 1) was written in 356 and the second (*Or.* 3) in 358. See Tougher 2012:21; Bowersock 1978:43 n. 10; cf. Drake 2012:39.

[15] Athanassiadi 1992:62 refers to the first panegyric's 'studied unoriginality'. For similar views, see Kennedy 1983:27.

[16] Both 2012. See also Athanassiadi 1992 and Curta 1995 for the atypical, self-promoting nature of the second panegyric.

[17] *Or.* 1.27a-29a and *Or.* 3.62a-67a.

[18] See 'Ammianus, sieges and intertextuality' below for the siege as a topos of historiography.

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Indeed, the generic proximity of historiography and panegyric has brought Julian's depiction of Nisibis under fierce criticism for its deviation from other parallel accounts. Later versions of the siege appear in the fifth-century ecclesiastical historian Theodoret, the seventh-century *Chronicon Paschale* and the twelfth-century historian Zonaras.[19] Those who criticise Julian point to striking similarities between Julian's version of Nisibis and the siege of Syene in Book 9 of Heliodorus of Emesa's novel, the *Aethiopica*.[20] Both strongholds were surrounded with dykes, between which and the walls the waters of passing rivers (the Nile at Syene and the Mygdonius at Nisibis) were diverted to create a flood. Upon this artificial lagoon ships assailed the walls.[21] In both cases the flood waters subsided and the wall collapsed. Sapor at Nisibis failed to press home this advantage, whereas the defenders at Syene surrendered but made an escape.

By contrast, several of these more fabulous events do not appear in the parallel sources for Nisibis, especially ship-borne troops sailing upon the artificial lake. The ferocity of the debate over the relationship between Julian and Heliodorus has perhaps stemmed from a misunderstanding of the functions of narrative in panegyric.[22] Those who argue that Heliodorus imitates Julian assume that 'the notion of Julian's borrowing from a work of fiction in official praise of an emperor concerning a recent historical event seems so obviously absurd.'[23]

These critics place too much weight on a cognitive function of Julian's speeches by assuming that Julian's primary reason for including the narrative of the siege was to provide a record of events. However, Rees has demonstrated in the context of the *panegyrici Latini* that at the moment of

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[19] Theodoret's account seems to conflate details of an earlier siege of Nisibis in the 340s and the siege of 350 (*HR* 1.11-12, *HE* 2.30.2-14). The *Chronicon Paschale* (pp. 536-37 Dindorf) purports to draw on a lost eyewitness account of a bishop, and Zonaras (13.7.2-13) may also record a now-lost source. For an analysis of the competing accounts of the siege, see Lightfoot 1988.

[20] Szepessy 1975 and 1976; Lightfoot 1988:117-18.

[21] Hld. 9.5.5; Jul. *Or.* 1.28b.

[22] There are two prevailing views: either Julian alludes to Heliodorus (removing the strongest argument for a fourth-century date for Heliodorus) or Heliodorus alludes to Julian (establishing a *terminus post quem* of 355 for Heliodorus). The latter was first noted by Van der Valk in 1941. This argument was endorsed and reinforced by Keydell 1966 and Lacombrade 1970 and is supported by Bowersock 1994 and Tantillo 1997:305-11. The contrary view was argued by Szepessy 1975 (restated at greater length in 1976) and is supported by Swain 1996:423 and Bowie 2008:32-35.

[23] Bowersock 1994:154.

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the speech's delivery, the cognitive function was relatively unimportant: 'there can be no cognitive function when the orator's challenge is to say what is already known ... the wider audience attending the speech would already have some knowledge of the honorand's relevant *res gestae* as evidenced by their attendance at the ceremony at which the panegyric was being delivered.'[24] The same could apply to Julian, but his case is somewhat different. The second panegyric may never have been sent to Constantius at all, and the first was certainly not read in the presence of Constantius by its author.[25] There may have been no performance context to act as a control for the factual content of the speeches. Julian himself states that as an orator he has τὴν ἐξουσίαν τοῦ πλάσματος, 'the licence to invent' (*Or.* 1.2b). In comparison to the other sources for Nisibis, Julian certainly seems to have adhered to the broad outline of the siege: the use of the river in some form, the collapse of the wall, and the failure of Sapor to take advantage of this opportunity. However, for the sake of entertainment and glorification of Constantius' achievement he has been selective in the events he narrates, and even inventive with the detail. Julian seems to revel in the ship-borne attack (not mentioned in the other sources),[26] which he presents as an *adynaton*.[27]

Indeed, the Heliodorus-Julian debate is testament to quite how much leeway the panegyricist had for *inventio* in his speech when it was removed from the kind of traditional performance context that Rees assumes for the *panegyrici Latini*. More important to Julian were the evidentiary and celebratory functions of narrative, which could be enhanced by *inventio*, provided this did not compromise the essential details of the siege. Julian clearly selects the most dramatic stages for inclusion in his account, the paradoxical marvels, the devastation caused by the defenders, 'the lake was turned to gore, and all about the walls echoed the groans of the barbarians, slaying not, but being slain,' and, in the second speech, the elephants floundering in the mud after the waters had receded.[28]

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[24] Rees 2010:110.

[25] First panegyric, Tougher 2012:22; second panegyric, Drake 2012:41.

[26] The other sources suggest Sapor diverted the river and used its waters as a sort of battering ram against the walls. Lightfoot 1988:115.

[27] Ταύτην ἥλιος ἐπεῖδε τὴν μάχην ἄγνωστον ἀνθρώποις τὸν ἔμπροσθεν χρόνον ('on that day the sun beheld a battle the like of which no man had ever known before', *Or.* 1.2b).

[28] *Or.* 1.27d; *Or.* 2.65b. Cf. Rees' example (2010:115) of the celebratory function of the narrative of Constantine's siege of Susa of 312 in *Pan. Lat.* 12(9).5.6.

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Such moments make the celebratory function of the narrative plain to see, but more puzzling is whether there can also be an evidentiary function. In using Nisibis to illustrate Constantius' military prowess, Julian faced an essential problem: Constantius was not present at the siege, the defence was merely carried out under his name. In other panegyrics to Constantius composed in the mid- to late-340s by Libanius and Themistius, both authors skirt over the events of the two earlier successful defences of Nisibis under Constantius in the 340s.[29] In his second oration to Constantius in 355, Themistius makes the briefest of allusions to the third siege of 350.[30] Presumably this was in part due to the problem of Constantius' lack of direct involvement. Julian, by contrast, includes an extensive narrative of the siege in both of his speeches.

Using this anomaly as a starting point, I intend to investigate Julian's use of Nisibis from an evidentiary, rather than merely celebratory point of view. How did Julian make use of narrative to present the defence of Nisibis as an ethically positive act by the absent Constantius?

The characterisation of armies and leaders at Nisibis

In both sieges, Julian restricts the cast of characters to four main players: Constantius, Sapor and the collective presentation of the two armies. No commander, and certainly not any individual soldier, is mentioned or described by Julian. The intervention of other main characters on the Roman side, such as the commander Lucillianus (mentioned by Zosimus) or St Jacob (in Ephrem and Theodoret), has no place in Julian's narrative.[31] This approach allows Julian to create narrative space in which he can present the siege as a personal tussle between Sapor and Constantius.

Sapor and the Persians are presented in a way that is familiar from historiographical representations of the enemies of Rome. In the first panegyric, Sapor has gathered together 'all forces (πᾶσαν) of every age, sex and condition.'[32] Julian thus deploys a typical 'barbarian horde' motif.[33]

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[29] Libanius' panegyric is dated to 344, Themistius' between 347 and 349; cf. Lieu & Montserrat 1996:161.

[30] Lieu & Montserrat 1996:163. Themistius *Or.* 2.37a; Vanderspoel 1995:93 n. 96; Leppin & Portman 1998:63 n. 71.

[31] Zosimus 3.8.2, Ephrem *CN* 13.19.12; Theodoret *HE* 2.30.2.

[32] *Or.* 1.27a.

[33] For the 'barbarian horde' motif in historiography, see Kraus 1994a:131 and Ash 2007:439. It was a common motif also in the later Empire: Lact. *De Mort. Pers.*

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However, the greater part of the narration is designed to belittle Sapor and the Persians and therefore to magnify the Roman triumph. Julian has to tread a narrow path between presenting Sapor simultaneously as a credible threat and a derisible enemy.[34] Thus the Persians are given a clear and immense objective, not just the capture of Nisibis, but to turn the whole of Roman Mesopotamia into their colony, introducing 'colonists' (κληρούχους).[35] Sapor does not commit to rationalistic planning, but is motivated in his attacks by 'rage' (τῇ μανίᾳ).[36]

Sapor is given a more rationalistic role in the second panegyric: rather than being motivated primarily by emotions, he responds to each setback by issuing new orders (65d, 66a). His tactical failing in the second siege scene is not his propensity to be overly angry or acquisitive, but to lack imagination in how to respond to his troops' failures; he 'employed the same efforts (τοῖς αὐτοῖς … παλαίσμασι) over again.'[37]

Sapor and the Persians are presented as an immense and credible threat to the Roman State. Their characteristics of rage and excess simultaneously help to reinforce their sense of menace, whilst also condemning them for the wrong sort of motivations. On an evidentiary level, Julian uses some of the typical features of narrative, the connection of cause and action, to denigrate the honorand's enemy.

Even if Sapor could easily be presented as a major threat to Rome, Julian faced a challenge to connect Constantius, as the subject of the panegyric, to the successful defence of Nisibis due to the latter's absence from the scene. Julian surmounts this by attributing the major cause for Sapor's failure not to the tenacity of the defenders, but to Constantius' preparations for defending the city. In the first speech, 'the magnitude of your preparations made it manifest that [the Persians'] expectations were but vanity (κενάς).'[38] The critical role of the (absent) Constantius is placed prominently at the outset of the scene before the description of Sapor's

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9.7. We find it also in the second panegyric: στρατὸς ἀμήχανος πλήθει ('an army irresistible in number', *Or.* 3.62b).

[34] A feature also common in 'patriotic' historiography. A classic example is Livy's presentation of the Carthaginians; see Adler 2011:86. Drijvers 2011:75 attributes this dichotomy in later historians' approach to the Persians to 'the need to create a worthy enemy, particularly because the Roman Empire suffered heavy defeats at the hands of the Sassanian army in Late Antiquity.'

[35] *Or.* 1.27b.

[36] *Or.* 1.28c.

[37] *Or.* 3.66c.

[38] *Or.* 1.27b

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first attack. Conversely, Sapor is present, but little attempt is made to explain his decision-making. As noted above, rage is his main motivation.

Julian uses the same approach to involve Constantius in the second speech, attributing the Persians' failure to capitalise upon the breach in the wall, the turning point in the siege, to 'the preparations of the emperor (ἡ βασιλέως παρασκευὴ).'[39] Exactly what these preparations were Julian does not make clear.

In order to give his narrative an evidential as well as a purely emotive function, Julian has carefully shaped his depiction of Nisibis to attribute the fundamental strategic aspect of Roman success to the absent Constantius. Sapor and the two armies are used primarily to emphasise the scale of the threat to the Roman East, and to narrate scenes of splendid and dramatic combat and slaughter. It is notable that there is no significant decision-making amongst the Roman troops, merely action, and Julian has been careful to select the phases of the siege which contain the most remarkable feats.[40]

Julian's is the earliest extant account of Nisibis. Even the Syriac poems of Ephrem were not composed until ten years after the event, and in any case most likely did not receive a wide circulation beyond the Syriac-speaking East. It has been claimed that the later Greek texts, Theodoret and the *Chronicon Paschale*, rely upon earlier Syriac sources, but these are all as unlikely as Ephrem to have gained an audience in the predominantly Greek- and Latin-speaking areas of the Empire.[41] Thus, Julian's account of the siege is the only Greek version that we know was in circulation before the publication of Eunapius and Ammianus around 390.[42] This is implied by Zosimus, who excuses himself for not offering a detailed description of the siege, instead directing his reader to Julian 'since Caesar [Julian] has told everything that happened there in his own writings [i.e. the panegyrics], and anyone who picks them up can also appreciate his great

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[39] *Or.* 3.66b.

[40] For Julian's selection, see Tantillo 1997:308.

[41] Theodoret seems to have used Ephrem (Maróth 1979). The *Chronicon Paschale* (pp. 216-18) purports to have used a letter written by Vologaeses, bishop of Nisibis in the 350s. Zonaras represents a different tradition, which may not stem from the contemporary Syriac accounts. The source for this section of his history remains unclear. See Lightfoot 1988:112; Banchich & Lane 2009:8-11.

[42] Eunapius is preserved in an abbreviated form by Zosimus *c.* AD 500 and in some fragments (none of which contain the description of the siege of Nisibis). Ammianus' first extant Book, 14, begins its narrative only in AD 353. The original account of Nisibis in both these authors, therefore, is now lost.

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literary skill.'[43] If Zosimus owes this deference directly to Eunapius, it would suggest that Julian's account remained the only Greek version in circulation until the 390s at the earliest.

Irrespective of their historicity, Julian's accounts of Nisibis were the definitive version of the siege in wide circulation for several decades after the event.

Ammianus, sieges and intertextuality

Western literature begins with a siege. The siege of Troy as depicted in Homer's *Iliad*, combining both graphic description of combat and the social effects upon family and society, provided a prototype for countless subsequent authors to focus on the capture of cities as set-pieces in a range of literary genres.[44] As G.M. Paul has traced, the motif of the *urbs capta* spread throughout oratory and poetry, where the standard elements of the killing of men, plundering of the city and lamentations of women and children were often deployed to invoke *miseratio*.[45] So familiar became the topos and the rhetorical uses to which it was put that the mere mention of *urbs capta*, without any further elaboration or narrative was often enough to have the desired effect.[46] In historiography particularly, descriptions of the siege and capture of a city proliferated during the Hellenistic period to such an extent that Polybius complains that authors would often write up sieges using stock elements where there was little historical accuracy underpinning their accounts.[47] In Livy, the investment and capture of cities takes on an ontological importance as an essential corollary to the foundation of Rome; Troy is destroyed before the founding of Lavinium,

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[43] Zosimus 3.8.2. Zosimus incorrectly attributes this siege to 359, confusing it (perhaps tellingly) with the siege of Amida in that year, which he otherwise does not mention; cf. Ridley 1982 *ad loc.*

[44] In Latin literature, it is found in the fragments of Ennius' dramatic works (*Scaenica* 92-99, 366-69); cf. Paul 1982:148-49. The sack of Troy appears in Book 2 of Virgil's *Aeneid*; subsequently the besieged become the besiegers when Aeneas attacks Latium, 12.554-92.

[45] As prescribed by Quintilian, *Inst.* 8.3.67. Paul 1982:150-51 cites examples from Cicero (*Rhet. Her.* 4.39.51; *Sull.* 19; *Dom.* 98) and Caesar's speech in Sallust's *BC* (51.9).

[46] Paul cites Catullus 62.20-24. Plautus and some elegists manipulate the convention for comic or light-hearted effect (e.g. Plautus, *Bacch.* 925ff.; Propertius 4.8.55-56). Cf. Paul 1982:151.

[47] Polybius 29.12.4; Paul 1982:145.

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Alba Longa before Rome.[48] The siege scene, incorporating both the investment and capture of a stronghold, became a historiographical set-piece which is 'arguably the most famous of all literary *topoi*'.[49]

In resurrecting the long-dormant genre of classicising historiography in Latin, Ammianus includes several siege scenes within his narrative. Most take place on the eastern frontier, where the warfare with Rome's sophisticated rival Persia was predicated on the acquisition and maintenance of strongholds.[50] By far the most extensive in the surviving book is the description of the siege of Amida by Sapor in 359, which fills most of Book 19, and is the first major siege scene of the extant portion of the text. Sapor invaded Roman territory, capitalising on the Emperor Constantius' absence from the front. The Roman forces were ill-prepared and soon thrown into a state of confusion, brilliantly evoked by Ammianus' first person singular narrative at the end of Book 18.[51] Cut off from his unit by the advancing Persians, Ammianus makes a hurried retreat to Amida. He graphically describes his final night out in the open on a narrow path outside the walls, 'in front of me a soldier with his head cut in two, and split into equal halves by a powerful sword stroke, was so pressed on all sides that he stood erect like a stump.'[52] Yet it is at this point that Ammianus the individual participant disappears from view. A formal description of the topography and history of Amida follows (18.9), before the rest of the siege is narrated either in the third person, or the first person plural (19.1-8), until Ammianus reappears to make a timely escape from the fallen city with a first person singular: *evado* (19.8).

Ammianus' first-person narration belies the essential oddity of Amida's inclusion at such length within the *Res Gestae*. Amongst Ammianus' contemporaries there was certainly the recognition that Amida was a significant loss for the Romans, but they represent the events of Constantius'

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[48] Serres 1991:38. Kraus 1994b:270-72 notes there are several Trojan echoes in Livy's description of the sack of Veii.

[49] Kraus 1994b:270.

[50] In addition to Amida 19.1-9, Singara is taken by Sapor in 360 (20.6); Bezabde is besieged twice, once by Sapor (20.7) and the second time by Constantius (20.11) in the year 360; Aquileia is besieged by Julian in his war against Constantius in 360 (21.12); Pirisabora by Julian during his Persian campaign of 363 (24.2); and also 'Maiozamalcha' during the same campaign (24.4). A number of sieges are mentioned in passing, but not narrated in an extensive 'siege scene', e.g. Reman and Busan immediately prior to Amida (18.10).

[51] 18.6-8.

[52] 18.8.12: 'The most exciting escape narrative in an ancient historian' according to Marincola 1997:201.

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subsequent Mesopotamian campaign in 360 as equally severe. Eutropius does not single out Amida amongst the generalising list of 'captured towns, besieged cities and slaughtered armies' during these years.[53] Festus records Amida alongside Singara as a major loss.[54] Jerome names Bezabde and Amida together, giving equal weight to each.[55] Even Libanius, when condemning Constantius in his funeral oration for Julian, does not make a special case for Amida as a particularly awful disaster.[56] Constantius was in no position to come to the rescue personally in 359. He had spent the winter of 358/59 in Sirmium, from where he launched defensive campaigns against the Limigantes, a Sarmatian tribe which had broken out of its allotted tribal area.[57]

Viewed against contemporary responses to the losses on the eastern front in 359-360, Ammianus' account seems unbalanced. The description of the siege of Amida fills twenty Teubner pages (18.10-19.9), whereas Sapor's two subsequent sieges of Mesopotamian strongholds the following year are treated far more summarily: Singara receives only one and a half (20.6) and Bezabde three and a half pages (20.7). The parallel sources suggest Amida was no more significant a loss for Constantius than Singara or Bezabde.[58] In addition to this historical reason, Amida should be viewed as an anomaly historiographically: for a Latin historian to write about his own participation in the events of his narrative, using the first person, is a peculiarity for the genre. Ammianus' extensive references to his own

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[53] Eutrop. *Brev.* 10.10.1: *captis oppidis, obsessis urbibus, caesis exercitibus.*

[54] Festus, *Brev.* 27.

[55] Jerome, *Chronicon, s.a.* 348 p236.l. Jerome includes a note summarising Constantius' failures during the years 348-360 placed under the year 348.

[56] Libanius, *Or.* 18.208. Libanius does not name any city or stronghold specifically, but he alludes to Singara in 348 and the siege of Nisibis in 350 as the two worst episodes of Constantius' eastern career (in the absence of any actual Roman defeat, he has to resort to condemning Constantius for destroying the moral of his army). Zosimus (3.8) concentrates on a siege of Nisibis in 359. It is probable that he is confusing this with an earlier Persian attack. It is notable, however, that he fails to mention Amida. One might have expected Julian to refer to these significant losses as part of his condemnation of Constantius in the *Letter to the Athenians*, but he does not.

[57] Amm. Marc. 19.11.1. Cf. *CTh* 6.4.14, 15 (Sirmium 22nd May) and *CTh* 1.7.1 (Sirmium 28th May).

[58] Paschoud 1989:48 argues that this can be corroborated from the Persian point of view: Sapor viewed Amida as strategically unimportant as he chose to destroy rather than garrison it himself after its capture.

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exploits as a soldier-participant within sections of his narrative are unique among extant examples of historiography.[59]

For some scholars, Ammianus' participation at Amida is reason enough to justify his elaboration of such an extensive siege scene. The historian indulges in an elaborate memoir of an event in which he took part twenty-five years previously. Thus Matthews, with his characteristic historically-positivist approach, views Amida largely as a reliable record of what Ammianus experienced.[60] More recently Lenski and Kagan, in the wake of the work of Sir John Keegan, use Ammianus as a test-case for 'face of battle' narrative theory. Both rely on Ammianus' credentials as an eye-witness, who accurately recorded what he experienced, in order to make use of his text as a unique participant's view of Late Antique combat.[61]

It is a curiosity of Ammianean scholarship that this same first person narrative has also aroused in François Paschoud a fervent suspicion of the historian's veracity.[62] Amida, he argues, is largely the historian's 'affabulation' – a scene aggrandised primarily by creating forced parallels with the siege of Troy.[63] First person narration is an attempt to grant authority to a largely constructed scene. Gavin Kelly, in a more cautious manner, is also suspicious of Ammianus' self-presentation at Amida. He notes that Ammianus confines his first-person appearances within the text to situations of solitude and peril, reflecting a carefully constructed self-presentation, which Kelly reads as an authorial comment on the nature of his work:

> The implications of these choices are historiographical: the literal loneliness of Ammianus acts as a metaphor for his loneliness in the field of history. By showing himself alone, he suggests that his historical testimony is unique. And by giving prominence to the perils that he faced and to the chances that permitted his survival,

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[59] Marincola 1997:201. Even allowing for losses it is difficult to find a parallel for Ammianus' personal involvement, which has been likened by Matthews to 'a Hollywood screenplay rather than solemn Roman history.' Matthews 1983:34.

[60] Matthews 1989:57-66.

[61] Kagan 2006:25-29 and Lenski 2007. Both respond to Keegan 1976.

[62] Paschoud 1989 and 1999.

[63] To take one of Paschoud's examples, Ammianus describes a battle which erupted over the corpse of the son of Sapor's client-king Grumbates (in revenge for whom, Sapor decides to besiege Amida). Paschoud suspects the incident: what interest could the inhabitants of Amida have in taking possession of this corpse? To do so, they would have to make a dangerous sortie from their walls, and no such sortie is mentioned in the text (1999:81). See Kelly 2008:59-60 for the Trojan elements of Amida.

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> he emphasises that the survival of his literary work … had hung … by a horse hair.[64]

The majority of scholars have begun their studies of Amida from a reading of Ammianus' first-person narration. Though they arrive at varying conclusions, these views are not entirely incompatible. Ammianus may well have melded his experiences of twenty-five years earlier with the literary characteristics of the siege scene that establishes history more widely in a literary tradition. Such views, if they are reconcilable, portray a complex episode in Ammianus' history, where autopsy intermingles with allusion to the historiographical tradition.

Intratextually, too, Amida plays a programmatic role in the *Res Gestae*. The siege scene, of which Amida is the first example within the extant books, assumes a formulaic pattern, an oscillation of focus upon the besieged and the attackers, culminating in an essential event which would explain the outcome of the scene.[65] Amida is the most extensive example of its type, and sets up the pattern for future redeployment and subtle variation in the following books of the history.

Despite the regular structure of each siege within the *Res Gestae*, Claire Sotinel has recently demonstrated that details individual to each scene can be distinctive enough to suggest Ammianus can also use sieges as points of intertextuality with other authors. Julian's forces besieged the Italian city of Aquileia during the civil war with Constantius in 361. Sotinel adduces that Ammianus deliberately models the scene on the description of an earlier siege of Aquileia in 238 in Book 8 of Herodian.[66] Both authors mention the wealth of the city; in both cases the city closes its gates against a perceived illegitimate pretender; in both, their actions are presented as a political act which represents the attitude of the rest of Italy against a non-Italian emperor (Maximin was Thracian, Julian Greek); in both, the decisions are taken by 'representatives of power' – senators in 238 and military commanders in 360 – rather than by the inhabitants; the city is not captured in either case, but opens its gates, in 238 after the murder of the tyrant, and in 360 once questions of Julian's legitimacy have evaporated upon news of Constantius' death. Sotinel argues that Ammianus' purpose in creating these parallels is to emphasise a contrast between

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[64] Kelly 2008:72.

[65] E.g. Sabbah 1978:579-82, 585-88 and Matthews 1989:288-90. Examples of the turning point: at Amida the collapse of the wall (19.8.2), at Singara the introduction of the ram (20.6.6).

[66] Sotinel 2005:57-59.

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the illegitimate tyrant Maximin and Julian, in order to reinforce the latter's (dubious) legitimacy.

Sotinel's observations raise some important points for the reading I propose of Amida. Ammianus here engages with a Greek text narrating a different event in a different period, but the same scene-type in the same genre. Sotinel has identified an intertextuality which operates through the deployment in meaningful ways by a later author (Ammianus) of similar themes, strategies of presentation and content-matter in an earlier author (Herodian) She nowhere suggests that Ammianus makes lexical allusions to Herodian.[67]

Sotinel's intertextual reading, however, is not the dominant sort commonly investigated in works of Latin literature. Studies of intertextuality frequently divide along two axes according to their attitude to the role of authorial intention and the nature of the 'markers' of intertextuality. Classicists have tended to adhere to a form of intertextuality which identifies intentional allusive practices identified lexically, that is, by the repetition or noticeable alteration of similar words or phrases of an earlier author by a later author.[68] Thus, it is intentional and lexically marked. The term most commonly used for this is 'allusion'.[69] The later author intends to make the allusion, and expects his readership's interpretation of his text to be enhanced by its identification. But allusion is

[67] It should be noted that Sotinel does not refer explicitly to any form of intertextual theory in her study of Aquileia.

[68] Latin poetics has played a dominant role in the study of intertextuality amongst literary studies of the ancient world. Although not inventing the concept, Conte 1986 acts as a model for several later studies of meaningful, intentional and lexical allusion in Latin poetry. Barchiesi 2001:147 largely follows Conte, and also suggests a similarity of approach between allusion in poetry and history. Fowler (e.g. 1997) anticipates a broader use of intertextuality, and Hinds 1998 argued in favour of a middle way between 'philological fundamentalism' (which demands the presence of lexical *comparanda* to identify an allusion) and 'intertextual fundamentalism' (which argues against authorial intention). Cf. Van Tress 2004: 20 and Marincola 2010:262.

[69] The terminology surrounding intertextual theory is not uniform (cf. Edmunds 2001:138). Here I use 'intertextuality' as an umbrella-term to refer to the phenomenon of engagement between texts, whether intentional or otherwise, on a range of levels, not just that of 'lexical allusion'. 'Lexical allusion' is therefore a specific kind of intertextuality, intentional and identified by lexical correspondences. This paper argues for the recognition of 'narrative allusion', where intentional correspondences are on the level of narrative presentation, strategy and content. Sotinel's study of Aquileia is, then, an example of 'narrative allusion'.

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just one form of intertextuality. As it was originally conceived by Julia Kristeva, intertextuality is an inherent aspect of writing within a language-system.[70] As a recent Classicist defines it, 'every text (it is argued) is constructed and needs to be understood against a background of assumptions and language derived from the mass of texts that preceded it, whether or not the author actively had any of those earlier texts in mind, or indeed had read them.'[71] Kristeva sits on the opposite end of the spectrum to most Classicists, her intertextuality being not necessarily intentional and marked by any meaningful similarity in the discourse.[72]

Sotinel's approach lies somewhere between these two positions: although what she proposes does not rely on lexical allusion, she nevertheless assumes a purposeful intertextuality of narrative technique and content. The strength of Sotinel's argument is that the similarities between the two depictions of Aquileia lend an extra layer of interpretation to Ammianus' text precisely if the intertextuality *is* purposeful, rather than accidental: Ammianus is actively passing comment on Julian by comparing him to Maximin.

Even though Sotinel does not openly draw upon intertextual theory, there have been several studies of historiography in recent years which have done so (indeed, 2010 seems to have been a golden year).[73] Several have focused on the same type of intertextuality as their peers in poetry, namely intentional lexical allusion,[74] but others have proposed different

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[70] Kristeva 1980.

[71] Levene 2010:83. Fowler, while acknowledging the extensiveness of intertextuality, also notes an essential problem (1997:24): 'it exaggerates the degree to which the literary System is a unified and stable one: it suggests that there is a single matrix which contains all the possibilities, and that we can therefore say that this or that intertextual relation is "there" in the System, waiting to be activated in reading.'

[72] A model roughly of this sort within Classics is Bartsch 1994:63-97, who argues that allusion in the form of political innuendo can be constructed by an audience when it identifies references to a contemporary political situation during the recitation of poetry or history, or the performance of a play. The allusion is not to another text but a historical situation, and it may not have been intended by the author.

[73] Riggsby 2006; Kelly 2008; O'Gorman 2009; Damon 2010; Levene 2010; Marincola 2010; Pelling 2010; Polleichtner 2010; Pelling 2013.

[74] O'Gorman 2009; Levene 2010:82-163 and the majority of the essays in Polleichtner 2010. After a discussion of the range of possible intertextual approaches, Levene confines himself to self-defined 'conservative' lexical allusion (2010:84). O'Gorman addresses the effect of intertextuality within a genre which

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approaches. Damon has suggested that historical events themselves can act as intertexts without the need for textual allusion,[75] and Pelling points to Xenophon's pervasive allusion to the 'Seven against Thebes' in his description of the liberation of the Cadmeia in a way which 'narrative modeling' rather than lexical allusion secures the intertext.[76]

A historian's purposeful intertextual engagement does not have to be confined to lexical allusion.[77] Furthermore, Aquileia also demonstrates two important features of Ammianus' siege scenes: his ability to characterise the combatant sides even if the commander for whom they fight (Julian at Aquileia) is not present at the scene himself; and his ability to establish intertextualities with Greek authors, based upon *comparanda* of theme, scene and presentation.

Ammianus, Amida and Nisibis

Although Ammianus alludes heavily to Troy in his description of Amida, the Mesopotamian setting, the Persian enemy and Constantius' involvement align Amida far more closely with Julian's description of Nisibis. There is no doubt that Ammianus knew Julian's works intimately, including the panegyrics. He mentions two by name, the *Misopogon* and

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purports to narrate past events, particularly on constructions of temporality and the effects on historical interpretation.

[75] Damon 2010:382 argues that Tacitus allusively suggests that the civil wars of AD 69 were a repetition of those of the Late Republic, though there are few 'verbal echoes' in Tacitus of extant narratives of those wars (e.g. as in Suetonius). Even though she approaches the issue of intertextuality from a different angle, her study demonstrates the recognisable intertextuality of narrative-patterns in, for example, the plot to assassinate an obstinate ruler (Julius Caesar~Galba) without the presence of lexical allusion.

[76] Pelling 2013:13-16. There are examples of 'narrative allusion' in other genres; Heliodorus of Emesa alludes to the structure of the *Odyssey* by beginning his novel, the *Aethiopica*, *in medias res*. There is no lexical allusion to Homer in the opening scene, but it has been argued that intertextuality with the *Odyssey* is an important interpretative tool throughout the novel. Cf. Morgan & Harrison 2008:224.

[77] It should be noted that Herodian is also a source for Ammianus' lexical allusion (Kelly 2008:231-40). Although the allusions do not appear during either author's narrative of Aquileia, their presence alongside Sotinel's narrative-allusion mutually strengthen the argument for the identification of each type of intertextual engagement.

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the (now lost) *Letter to the Senate of Rome*.[78] More importantly, Ammianus used Julian's panegyrics as allusive source-texts for his history. He put Julian's words of praise of Eusebia (*Oration* 2) into the mouth of Constantius during the latter's speech elevating Julian to the Caesarship in Book 15.[79] Julian's image of the cataphracts (heavily armed cavalry equipped, trained and used by Constantius against the usurper Magnentius) appearing like statues in the first panegyric to Constantius (*Oration* 1) is redeployed by Ammianus in his description of Constantius' *adventus* in Rome in Book 16.[80] Both allusions are deployed to criticise Constantius.

Returning now to my earlier discussion of Julian, I suggest that Ammianus derives some features of his presentation of the two principal characters at Amida, Sapor and Constantius, from Julian's depiction of Nisibis. Thus there is intertextuality between Julian's Nisibis and Ammianus' Amida of a sort similar to Sotinel's between Herodian and Ammianus' Aquileias. At Nisibis, Julian had created a Sapor who led a barbarian horde intent upon conquering the whole Roman East; he was motivated by negative emotions, but was kept by Julian on the periphery of the scene, rather than used as a causative force during the progress of the siege. Constantius was artificially drawn into the scene by the attribution of the Roman success not to the tenacity and ingenuity of the defenders, but to Constantius' (undefined) 'preparations.'

Ammianus' Sapor and Constantius appear prominently in the Amida scene because Ammianus' narrative resembles Julian's in an important way – he elides description of any other individuals.[81] There is certainly a clear distinction between the Persians and Romans, but no individual commander is named during the progress of the siege. The reader is informed of the *comes* Aelianus and *numerarii* of the *magister equitum* Jacobus and Caesius only after the scene is concluded and their names are given during an

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[78] *Misopogon* 22.14.2; *Letter to the Roman Senate* 21.10.7.

[79] 15.8.14~*Or.*3.123b. Cf. Pighi 1936:60.

[80] 16.10.8~*Or.*1.37c.; first noted by Lindenbrog 1609 *ad loc.* Sabbah 1978:306-08 argues that the wider allusion to Constantius' role in this civil war is an attempt by Ammianus to condemn Constantius for celebrating an unseemly triumph over Roman blood.

[81] Sapor's client-king Grumbates and his son play no further role after the latter's death, the event which prompts Sapor to besiege the city rather than pass it by (19.2.6). They are not part of the siege scene proper. Likewise, the Roman commanders Ursicinus and Sabinianus, who were technically in charge of the defence of Amida, can only be incorporated into the narrative by means of a sudden change of scene at 19.3, where the narrative focus shifts away momentarily from Amida to Edessa, thus emphasizing their absence.

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enumeration of Romans executed by Sapor once the city has fallen.[82] Ammianus even removes himself partially from the scene. Although he readily describes his own actions in the build-up to the siege in Book 18 using the first person singular, he uses only the first person plural or third person plural during the progress of the siege.[83] His actions merge into the overall perspective of the defenders in a way that is reminiscent of the convention of patriotic Roman historiographers which applies first person possessive adjectives (*noster*) to the Romans in war even when the historian makes no suggestion that he, too, was amongst the participants.[84] The overall effect of this reduction in *dramatis personae* is the same as in Julian: Sapor or Constantius appear all the more prominently due to the lack of any rival characters.

Ammianus' Sapor exhibits many of the same characteristics as Julian's incarnation of him at Nisibis. He rashly approaches the walls of Amida, expecting that his appearance alone will induce the defenders through fear (*metu*) to surrender to him. He does so 'too rashly' (*confidentius*) and when he becomes a target for the defenders' missiles, his confidence turns to 'rage' (*saeviens*).[85] Otherwise, Sapor has little to do with the operations of the siege. He does not appear in the narrative again until the final episode of the siege, where his personal engagement in the battle ('a new thing, never heard of before') signals the culmination of the Persians' final and successful assault, driven by his 'anger' (*ira*).[86]

Ammianus is keen to stress that Amida was a pyrrhic victory for the Persians, who had been waylaid from their primary objective, set out as the wholesale capture and colonisation of Roman territory in the East, an attempt 'to overrun everything' (*pervadere cuncta*).[87] At the end of the siege, Sapor must disguise his true feelings at his failure to press on any

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[82] 19.9.2. Aelianus had also been introduced with a note of his military achievements just before the start of the siege scene proper at 18.9.3. He is, however, allowed to play no role during the course of the siege in Book 19.

[83] The first person plural, especially, is not used to record anything remotely like strategic planning by the defenders. Instead, it is a tool for Ammianus to enhance the epic flavour of the scene. Thus 'we' wish to die gloriously or bravely: 'we despaired of any hope of safety and henceforth strove to end our lives gloriously', 19.2.4; 'we burned, not with the desire of saving our lives, but, as I have said, of dying bravely' ,19.2.13.

[84] Marincola 1997:287-88.

[85] 19.1.4-5.

[86] 19.7.8, 8.1.

[87] 18.4.1. Paschoud expresses severe doubts over Ammianus' interpretation of the Persian strategy (1989:48, 49).

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further into Roman territory – 'in the depths of his heart he raged greatly' (*graviter aestuabat*) – with a false show of exultation over the destruction of Amida.[88] This presentation of the Persian leader is typical of elsewhere in the *Res Gestae* where he is driven by his passions, particularly anger and a sense of pride.[89] This bears great resemblance to Julian's similar characterisation of Sapor and his limited strategic role within the siege itself. Sapor is a looming and threatening presence at Amida, a bogeyman who plots for the destruction of the Roman world, but has little practical involvement in the campaign that tries to realise his desire. Ammianus chooses to fit him into a standard pattern of anti-Persian propaganda, one of the most important recent manifestations of which is found in Julian's panegyrics.[90]

Constantius' involvement in the scene is necessarily artificially constructed by Ammianus, since the emperor was stationed in Sirmium during the summer of 359.[91] Constantius first appears in an element of Ammianus' siege scenes which was to become formulaic: the description of the topography and history of the citadel. Constantius' appearance here forms part of a historical note, mentioning his fortification of the once small (*brevem*) city so that it would become a significant obstacle for the Persians.[92] Ammianus sets up Constantius' involvement in the siege in a way which bears a close resemblance to Julian's attempts to connect Constantius' limited involvement with the successful defence of Nisibis. Of course, the essential difference in the outcome of the sieges reverses the purpose of this narrative strategy: Constantius' preparations at Amida fail to prevent the city's fall to the Persians, and therefore may be read as a criticism of the emperor.

Ammianus' narrative structure helps enforce the irony of Constantius' disingenuous care for the city: descriptions of the machinations at Constantius' court and its frustration of Ursicinus the *magister equitum*, who, according to Ammianus, is the only credible saviour of Amida, both pre-empt and break the siege narrative in two (18.4-6 and 19.5). When

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[88] 19.9.9.

[89] Drijvers 2011:71 identifies Sapor as possessing the opposing characteristics of the ideal Roman emperor.

[90] Procopius and Agathias continue this mode of negative presentation in their description of contemporary Persian monarchs; cf. Drijvers 2011:72-75.

[91] 18.4.1.

[92] 'He made it a terror to the enemy' (*fecit hostibus formidatam*, 18.9.1). Constantius probably increased the defences of the city to encompass roughly half of the area contained by the extant walls; cf. Gabriel 1940:180.

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Constantius does arrive in person at Amida the following year, it is too late, when he and his entourage coldly witness the crumbled walls of the city and are derisive towards the courage of the defenders. This episode appears in the subsequent book, detached in the narrative from the rest of the Amida scene (20.11.5); a further wry comment on the ineffectual nature of Constantius' involvement at Amida.

Ammianus' proven knowledge of Julian's panegyrics strengthens the case for reading Ammianus' presentation of Constantius and Sapor at Amida as an intertextuality with Julian's depiction of Nisibis. However, there is a missing element in our assessment of Ammianus' engagement with the siege of Nisibis, namely his own narrative of the event in one of the lost books. Falling only three years before the earliest events of Book 14, there is no doubt that Ammianus must have dealt with Nisibis in some form. The question is whether Ammianus lavished as much narrative upon Nisibis as he did Amida in Book 19, and whether Ammianus' Nisibis could have mediated the intertextuality between Amida and Julian's speeches. Discussions about lost works, necessarily, can never arrive at a definitive resolution, but there are clues in the extant portion of the *Res Gestae* that provide us with some suggestion of Ammianus' treatment of Nisibis.

Nisibis had been successfully defended against Sapor three times during Constantius' reign. The earlier sieges of Nisibis play an important role in colouring Ammianus' perceptions of imperial policy in Mesopotamia, especially the city's surrender by Jovian in 363. Ammianus attributes Persian strategising to Sapor's obsession with Nisibis, firstly presuming in early 359 that Nisibis must be the target of Sapor's invasion (18.6.8), then quickly reformulating his views to explain why Sapor unexpectedly 'passed by Nisibis as an unimportant halting place (*pro statione vili*).'[93] Ammianus could have no idea of the true reasons which lay behind Sapor's planning, and it is tempting to see this attribution as a derisory comment on Constantius' defence of Nisibis in 350 (though Constantius successfully defended the city, Sapor ultimately did not prize it as much as the Romans thought). That said, twice more the memory of what he had suffered at Nisibis is presented as the source of Sapor's reasoning and planning: 'recalling that in unfortunate sieges he had **often suffered** sad

[93] 18.7.8. Cf. also 18.6.8: *Nisibin propere venimus utilia paraturi, me dissimulantes obsidium Persae civitati supervenirent incautae.* Earlier 'we [Ammianus in the company of Ursicinus] hastily marched to Nisibis to prepare what was useful, lest the Persians … might surprise the city when off its guard.'

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losses (*reputans … **saepe** luctuosas se **pertulisse** iacturas*)'[94] and 'doubtless remembering what he had **too often suffered** there (*memor nimirum quae **saepius** ibi **pertulerat***).'[95] The language is similar on each occasion, reflecting Sapor's fixation with the city. This collective Persian memory also extends to Sapor's troops. When attacking Julian's army in Mesopotamia in 363, the Persian mahouts carry knives with them so they may slay their elephants should they get out of control, 'remembering the disaster suffered at Nisibis (*acceptae apud Nisibin memores cladis*).'[96]

Curiously, none of the characters' recollections of Nisibis provoke Ammianus as narrator to include a cross-reference to his earlier narration of this event. Following a tradition of Latin prose authors, Ammianus regularly draws the reader's attention to earlier episodes in his narrative by the inclusion of cross-referencing phrases such as *ut rettulimus*, *ante rettulimus*, *supra monstravimus* or the like.[97] No such phrase is found in connection with any of the historical notes given about Nisibis. Frakes, instead, has termed the references to the sieges of Nisibis as 'historical allusions', references to the collective knowledge of Nisibis shared by Ammianus and his intended readers, but not something he has specifically narrated in the earlier portions of the *Res Gestae*.[98] The wholesale omission by Ammianus of the third siege of Nisibis seems improbable, but that he treated it summarily is suggested by his allusions to the previous sieges when Jovian hands Nisibis over to Sapor as part of the peace treaty in 363.[99] Ammianus describes Nisibis as an 'impregnable (*inexpugnabilis*) city',[100] but the previous failed attempts which had earned it this epithet stretch back long before 350. Jovian is castigated for abandoning a city 'which ever since the time of King Mithridates' reign had resisted with all its might the occupation of the Orient by the Persians.'[101] Ammianus magnifies the shameful abandonment of Nisibis by placing its ability to withstand siege in a far longer continuum than merely the three assaults it

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[94] 19.9.9.
[95] 20.7.1.
[96] 25.1.15. Dodgeon & Lieu (1991:203) attribute this directly to the siege of Nisibis in 350.
[97] See Cichocka 1976:213-18 and Frakes 1995:243-45 for a complete list.
[98] Frakes 1995:234-40.
[99] As noted above (note 50), Ammianus has two distinct methods of narrating a siege, either the full-scale siege scene, or a shorter note. An example of the latter is the capture of Reman and Busan by Sapor in 359 before he arrived at Amida. It is possible that this is how Ammianus treated Nisibis in 350 in his lost narrative.
[100] 25.8.17.
[101] 25.9.8.

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suffered at the hands of Sapor during Constantius' reign. Indeed, Ammianus eclipses Constantius' successful defence of the city by alluding to the events of the mid-2nd century BC. This is a 'gross exaggeration,' as Nisibis had been fully in Roman control only since AD 298.[102]

It is likely that Ammianus avoided lavishing narrative space upon the third siege of Nisibis within his own (now lost) narrative.

Ammianus' intertextuality

We are now in a position to address the 'oddities' of Amida, to which I alluded earlier in this article. Ammianus reserved his first great siege scene on the eastern frontier for Amida. Amida was not prominently reported by other authors and such a decision required justification. Ammianus' first-person narration is deployed to provide just that justification; Ammianus benignly appears to break with Latin historiographical tradition to indulge in a detailed narration of an event in which he took part. In addition to autopsy, the alignment of Amida with the conventional portrayal of sieges connects Ammianus with the traditions of historiography, providing him with a further support for his authority. Yet, there is a more fundamental point underlying this need for authority.

Ammianus concludes his assessment of Constantius' life with the judgement that 'in foreign wars (*externis bellis*) he met with loss and disaster, yet he was elated by his success in civil conflicts (*pugnis civilibus*).'[103] Nisibis provides a threatening counter-example to his proposition, especially since the author responsible for aggrandising and popularising Nisibis is also the hero of Ammianus' narrative, Julian himself. Ammianus pre-empts this charge by subtly redeploying Julian's narrative techniques – using similar portrayals of Julian and Sapor, an expansive narrative and Homeric comparisons – and thereby supplants in Constantius' record the success of Nisibis with the failure of Amida. Ammianus thus uses intertextuality to take a 'corrective' approach to Julian's panegyric.

Ammianus' engagement with panegyric may seem surprising. The prominence of panegyric in the 4th century met with hostility from writers of history. Ammianus, Eutropius and Festus all present panegyric as the genre appropriate for contemporary events relating to the reigning

[102] Den Boeft *et al.* 2005:287, 297.
[103] 21.16.15.

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emperor, unsafe territory for a truth-loving historian.[104] Things changed, however, once the subject matter of a panegyric ceased to be contemporary and, with the speech's publication, became historical. After an emperor's death, a historian had to engage with published panegyrics, not least because they could include extensive sections of narrative which were historiographical in content though encomiastic in purpose.

There is merit in treating Ammianus as a careful reader of Julian's works. Of course, there are difficulties in comparing the two, but the style of intertextuality, that of narrative allusion, which I suggest here, overcomes some of them and may, in fact, reflect the importance of Ammianus' project. By supplanting Constantius' success at Nisibis with his failure at Amida, Ammianus was engaging in a politically contentious topic. His style of intertextuality, when dealing with a contemporary text such as Julian and an 'inappropriate' genre such as panegyric, reflects this concern. Whereas the allusions to Troy could be clearly marked ('as once upon a time at Troy', *ut apud Troiam quondam*) and even by reference to Troy's premier narrator *Homero auctore*,[105] Nisibis and Julian could not receive such obvious indication. Instead, narrative allusion takes the place of lexical allusion. Ammianus carefully reshaped contemporary depictions of Constantius and Julian into a definitive historical account which has endured to this day.

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[104] Matthews 1989:455. Eutr. *Brev.* 18.3; Festus, *Brev.* 30; Amm. Marc. 31.16.9. Kelly 2007:227-229. For the necessity of lying in panegyric, see Augustine's famous denunciation of the genre, *Conf.* 6.6.9.

[105] 19.1.9 and 19.4.6.

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